

EVOLVING CULTURAL PARADIGMS

Biological evolution supplies only a rough analogy for cultural evolution, but offers illuminating parallels. Within cultures, successful ideas or ‘memes’ are reproduced and passed between people. Like genes, memes aren’t selected on their own — rather they come together in packages, groups of ideas, like DNA. Like biological species, examples of these cultural codes vary in their attributes. Different societies throughout history have shared similar **base cultural paradigms** comprising particular sets of core views and values.

Punctuated equilibria

Scholars and theorists of cultural evolution observe a historic tendency for cultural paradigms to change over centuries. Like genetic evolution, paradigms display punctuated equilibria — periods of stasis punctuated by shifts that are gradual to begin with and then, beyond a tipping point, abrupt. Paradigm shifts entail widespread adoption of radically different worldviews and values, with transformative consequences for humanity’s behavior and relationship with the world. However, the ideas that will characterize the next paradigm often form *before* the shift itself.

Fig. 1
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

	Pre-Modern	Modern	Post-Modern
Art	One perspective Single truth, single cultural truth (shared story, tradition)	Perspective Single, "true" view	Multiple Perspective
Social Structures	Hierarchy Authority, duty	Individualism and Freedom Personalism ... Individualism ...	Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism Unity, unity, multiculturalism
Economic Structures (Concepts)	Feudal Tied to land, Communal	Capitalism and Commodities Profit, private property, market, individualism ... Authority with force	Signs and Information Purpose, intent, material, Awareness, Awareness by objects/idea, Purpose, all signs and information are "signifying", all meaning
Episteme	Revealed Truth via Religion	Power and Secrecy	Multiple valid perspectives As "Truth"
Center of Concern	God	Man	Ecosystem
Authority comes from ...	God and King	The People (Who discovered via Reason) 1 commands, 2 responds	It (Who authority?)
Valued / Worried		Being Right	Feeling good, Healing
Zone of Concern	Things can be measured e.g. conversion	Action	World to All Acting

Influential among such frameworks is the **Spiral Dynamics** model, which has evolved from the early work of Clare Graves via Beck and Cowan into the popular synthesis by Ken Wilber and the Integral movement.

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Fig. 2
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

	Pre-Modern	Modern	Post-Modern
Art	As perspective Being, truth, and cultural events layered over each other	Perspective Single, "true" eye	Multiple Perspective
Social Structures	Hierarchy Authority built	Individualism and Progress Results in individualism	Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism Unity, truth, and progress
Economic Structures (Concepts)	Feudal Trade and Commerce	Capitalism and Commodities Profit, growth, control, control, knowledge, and knowledge	Signs and Information Purpose, self-organizing? Progress, growth, control, knowledge, and knowledge Progress, growth, control, knowledge, and knowledge
Episteme	Revealed Truth via Religion	Power and Secrecy	Multiple valid perspectives as "truth"
Center of Concern	God	Man	Ecosystem
Authority comes from ...	God and King	The People Truth discovered via Reason 1. consensus, democracy	It Who authority?
Valued / Worried		Being Right	Feeling good, Healing
Zone of Concern	Things can be measured e.g. Creation	Action	World to All Actions

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Fig. 3
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

	Pre-Modern	Modern	Post-Modern
Art	No perspective Static, both inner and outer worlds (space and selection)	Perspective Single, "true" view	Multiple Perspective
Social Structures	Hierarchy Authority Status	Individualism and Progress Democracy Individualism ...	Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism Critique, chaos Relativism
Economic Structures (Concepts)	Feudal Trade is bad Commerce	Capitalism and Commodities Profit, growth, control Market Individualism ...	Signs and Information Subjects, De-Fragmentation? Progress, rapid cultural change, new management by networks Primary of signs and information by technology, who governs
Episteme	Revealed Truth via Religion	Reason and Science	Multiple valid perspectives No "Truth"
Center of Concern	God	Man	Ecosystem
Authority comes from ...	God and King	The People Truth discovered via Reason 1 consensus, 2 consensus	?? Who authority?
Valued / Hunted		Being Right	Feeling good, Healing
Zone of Concern	Thing can be measured e.g. CRISTIAN	Motion	World to All Actions

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Fig. 4
Features of the pre-modern, modern and post-modern paradigms.

	Pre-Modern	Modern	Post-Modern
Art	No perspective 3Dity, 4th view, natural world (upside down, sideways)	Perspective single, "true" view	Multiple Perspective
Social Structures	Hierarchy Authority Status	Individualism and Progress Democracy Individualism ...	Inclusivity, Cultural Relativism Critique, chaos Polycentricity
Economic Structures (Concepts)	Feudal Trade is bad Commodification	Capitalism and Commodities Profit, growth, control Market Standardization ... Profit-making with leverage	Signs and Information Subjects, De-Framing/Delegit? Big data, hyper-reality Networks, management by objectives Primary of signs and information by abstraction, into economy
Episteme	Revealed Truth via Religion	Reason and Science	Multiple valid perspectives No "Truth"
Center of Concern	God	Man	Ecosystem
Authority comes from ...	God and King	The People Truth discovered via Reason 1 consensus, 2 consensus	?? Who authority?
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